



STARTUPS



Waymo's Tekedra Mawakana on the truth behind autonomous vehicles at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

Autonomous vehicles have long been touted as “just around the corner,” but the reality of what it takes to bring self-driving cars to the streets is anything but simple. At [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27–29 at Moscone West in San Francisco, [Waymo](#) co-CEO Tekedra Mawakana joins the [Disrupt Stage](#) for a wide-ranging conversation on the current state of AVs — and where the industry goes from here.



Inside the self-driving reality check

While the headlines often focus on crashes, controversies, or overblown promises, Tekedra has spent years navigating the real-world path to autonomous mobility. At Disrupt, she'll dig into what it actually takes to scale AV deployment — from rider safety and public trust to the nuances of regulation, operations, and competitive pressure from Tesla and others.

This session isn't about vague timelines or flashy demos. It's about what's working, what still needs work, and what it means to bring truly autonomous vehicles to life at scale. Whether you're a founder, investor, or just curious about the road ahead, you won't want to miss it.

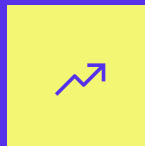
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IMAGE CREDITS: WAYMO

Meet the leader behind the wheel

[Tekedra Mawakana](#) brings over two decades of experience shaping global strategy for some of the world's biggest tech companies. As co-CEO of Waymo, she guides the company's long-term mission to bring the Waymo Driver to the masses and lead the next generation of autonomous innovation. She also serves on the board of Intuit, advises Boom Technology, and supports a number of social impact ventures through her work as an investor and LP with Operator Collective.

Get your pass to Disrupt before rates rise

Waymo's story is a central chapter in the future of mobility, and this session offers a rare inside look at the journey behind the headlines. Join us at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) — where more than 10,000 startup and VC leaders gather to shape what's next. [Register today](#) and secure your spot with up to \$675 in ticket savings before prices increase.



IMAGE CREDITS:KIMBERLY WHITE / GETTY IMAGES

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Wayve CEO Alex Kendall brings the future of

autonomous AI to TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 8:15 AM PDT · July 8, 2025

TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 hits Moscone West in San Francisco from October 27–29, bringing together more than 10,000 startup and VC leaders for a deep dive into the future of technology. One of the most compelling conversations on one of the AI Stages will feature a panel of innovators redefining what intelligent systems can do. Among them is [Alex Kendall](#), co-founder and CEO of Wayve.

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ALEX KENDALL

CEO, Wayve

From research breakthrough to real-world autonomy

Kendall founded [Wayve](#) in 2017 with a bold vision: to unlock autonomous mobility, not through handcrafted rules but through embodied intelligence. His pioneering research at the University of Cambridge laid the foundation for a new generation of self-driving systems powered by deep learning and computer vision. Under his leadership, Wayve became the first to prove that a machine could learn to interpret its

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surroundings and make real-time driving decisions — without relying on traditional maps or manual coding.

Today, Kendall is leading the charge toward AV2.0, an entirely new architecture for autonomous vehicles that is designed to scale globally. As CEO, he focuses on aligning strategy, research, partnerships, and commercialization to bring intelligent driving systems to the road. With a PhD in computer vision and robotics, award-winning academic work, and recognition on the Forbes 30 Under 30 list, Kendall is a rare blend of scientist, founder, and industry operator.

What to expect on the AI Stage

While full panel details are still under wraps, Kendall’s participation ensures that this session will offer more than just theoretical takes. Expect insights on how embodied intelligence can shift the trajectory of AI, the challenges of building systems that adapt to the real world, and what it takes to commercialize autonomy at scale.

Catch Alex Kendall live on one of the two [AI Stages at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27–29 at Moscone West in San Francisco. The exact session timing to be announced. [Register here](#) to join more than 10,000 startup and VC leaders and **save up to \$675** before prices increase.

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Get inside Disrupt: Volunteer at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 7:30 AM PDT · July 29, 2025

[TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) lands in San Francisco this October, and if you're eager to break into the tech world, here's your chance to be in the room where it all happens. We're looking for curious, driven [volunteers](#) to join our team at Moscone West from October 27–29, and help power one of the most iconic startup events in the world.

There's no better way to experience Disrupt and learn from the best

You'll do more than just lend a hand. As a volunteer, you'll get a behind-the-scenes look at the production of a high-energy tech event packed with big names, breakout startups, and some of the sharpest minds in AI, VC, and beyond. And yes —



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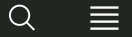
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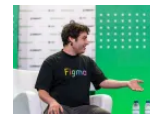
What you'll get

✓ Full access to Disrupt

After completing your volunteer shift, enjoy three days of full conference access, including sessions, networking, and startup showcases.

✓ Real-world experience

See firsthand how top-tier tech events come together, and connect with professionals across the startup and VC world.



Figma's IPO success is 'a little bit of a meme stock,' says Sapphire Ventures' Jai Das

Rebecca Bellan,
Theresa Loconsolo
- 14 hours ago

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Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the 'agent-native economy'

Dominic-Madori Davis
- 15 hours ago



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW



✓ Massive networking potential

Meet 10,000+ startup and VC leaders, join Braindate sessions, and plug into hundreds of side events happening around the city.

What we need from you

- A minimum of 10 hours of volunteer time during the event
- Attendance at a mandatory orientation on Sunday, October 26, at Moscone West
- Age 18+
- San Francisco/Bay Area locals preferred (but not required)

Ready to volunteer?

We're now accepting volunteer applications for TechCrunch Disrupt 2025. Get involved, get inspired, and get your foot in the door — [apply to volunteer](#) at Disrupt today.

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STARTUPS



Do startups still need Silicon Valley? Hear from the founders and funders challenging old assumptions at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 7:30 AM PDT · July 28, 2025

As the startup world descends on San Francisco for [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) — happening October 27-29 at Moscone West — one question looms large: Does building in Silicon Valley still give founders an edge? With 10,000+ startup and VC leaders gathering for this milestone Disrupt, the conversation around access, geography, and opportunity has never been more timely.

On the [Builders Stage](#), Anh-Tho Chuong (Lago), David Hall (Revolution), and Heather Doshay (SignalFire) lead a must-attend session for anyone looking to scale smart in today's startup landscape.

[Register now to save up to \\$675](#) before July ends and to join this (and many more sessions).



Why this conversation matters now

As distributed teams, regional hubs, and global fundraising become more normalized, founders are increasingly asking if their ZIP code actually gives them an edge. Does being in the Bay Area still open the right doors? Or has the playing field finally leveled?

This [session](#) brings together startup veterans and seasoned investors who've built and backed companies across the country — and well beyond it. They'll dig into what access looks like in 2025, how remote collaboration has evolved post-pandemic, and where true opportunity lies for emerging founders.

Who's taking the Builders Stage for this session

[Anh-Tho Chuong](#) is rethinking open source billing with [Lago](#), a YC-backed platform trusted by AI leaders like Mistral and Together. From her time scaling Qonto to her early roles at Weebly and McKinsey, she's no stranger to navigating growth across continents.

[David Hall](#) has spent the last decade proving that game-changing companies don't have to come out of Silicon Valley. As managing partner at [Revolution](#)'s Rise of the Rest Seed Fund, he's helped build a portfolio that spans the country —



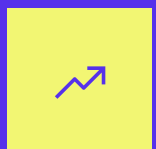
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backing bold founders in places often overlooked by coastal VCs.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

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[Heather Doshay](#) knows how to scale people-first organizations from the inside. As a partner at [SignalFire](#) and former VP of People at Webflow, she's seen how the hiring landscape has shifted for startups outside the Valley — and what it takes to build standout teams in a distributed world.

Join the debate at Disrupt

Whether you're building from a big city, a small town, or somewhere in between, this session will offer a fresh perspective on where startup success really comes from. Find out what still matters, what doesn't, and how to build your network — no matter your location.

Catch this panel live on the [Builders Stage](#) at Disrupt 2025, happening October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco. Tickets are moving fast, and prices increase after July — [register now to save up to \\$675](#) and lock in your spot.

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- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
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